Tigers roar past Walhalla in region opener

By Caleb James

For The Journal

IVA – For a brief stretch on Friday night, it looked like Walhalla might trade punches with Crescent and turn a region opener into a shootout.

Then, almost as quickly as it began, the Tigers slammed the door.

Fueled by a five-touchdown showcase from senior Amiri Acker, Crescent overwhelmed the Razorbacks 67-20 to open Western 3A play with a statement win.

Acker's fingerprints were everywhere, with four touchdown catches, a long rushing score, and a 75-yard kickoff return as Crescent (4-2, 1-0) piled up 663 yards of offense and broke the game open by halftime.

Walhalla (0-6, 0-1) delivered one of its best opening quarters of the season, matching Crescent's fireworks early behind quarterback Caleb Johnson. The Razorbacks struck on a 50-yard touchdown pass to Preston Patterson, then answered again when Johnson found Dylan Blackwell from 12 yards out to pull within 20-13.

That momentum, however, didn't last long.

Crescent erupted for 26 straight points in the second quarter, a flurry that included a 60-yard pick-six from Kaleb Dale and two more Acker scores, to seize control at the break, 46-13.

Crescent head coach Sheldon Evans said his team came in determined to clean up mistakes that had slowed them in recent games.

"Execution was our focus all week," Evans said. "We've shot ourselves in the foot a lot lately, but tonight our guys executed. And kudos to Walhalla, they came out and punched us in the mouth early. I was proud of how our kids responded."

Quarterback Mason Evans completed seven of nine passes for 285 yards and four touchdowns, while Kevin Hatten ran for 125 yards and a score. Acker's five-touchdown night, paired with 322 all-purpose yards, gave the Tigers all the spark they needed.

Despite the lopsided outcome, Walhalla head coach Blake Dyar said he saw reasons for optimism.

"There's no quit in them," Dyar said. "Think about kids like Essien Nathan running the ball as hard as he did down there. We're down nearly forty points, and he's running the ball as hard as he can, fighting for every yard. That's what it takes. We've got to get that fight out of everybody."

The Razorbacks posted 409 yards of total offense, including 287 on the ground. Dean rushed for 142 yards on ten carries, while Nathan added 126 yards and a touchdown on 22 attempts.

Dyar said Johnson’s continued growth at quarterback, now in his third start, remains a bright spot for the offense.

“Caleb’s doing a fantastic job,” Dyar said. “He’s progressing every week. There were times protection broke down or he missed a read, but that’s just going to come with time. I see tremendous growth in him and our receivers.”

Crescent tacked on three more touchdowns in the third quarter, runs from Evans and Hatten, followed by Acker’s final 42-yard grab.

For Dyar, the challenge now is channeling the fight he saw in flashes into four quarters of football.

“I expect them to do what they’ve done all year, come out Monday ready to work,” he said. “It doesn’t matter what the scoreboard says. This is a resilient group, and we’re going to keep getting better.”

Walhalla will return home next Friday night to face their next region opponent in the Pendleton Bulldogs, while Crescent hits the road for another region test against the West-Oak Warriors.

Crescent 67, Walhalla 20

CHS 20 26 21 0 — 67

WHS 13 0 7 0 — 20

SCORING SUMMARY

First Quarter

CHS — Acker 27 pass from Evans (kick failed), 9:29

WHS — Patterson 50 pass from Johnson (kick failed), 8:22

CHS — Geer-Harrison 44 pass from Evans (Pruitt kick), 5:51

WHS — Blackwell 12 pass from Johnson (Cobb Kick), 3:16

CHS — Acker 75 kickoff return (Locke kick), 3:04

Second Quarter

CHS — Dale 60 Pick-Six (kick failed), 11:15

CHS — Acker 38 pass from Evans (kick failed), 9:43

CHS — Acker 45 run (2 pt. Conv. failed), 6:27

CHS — Acker 44 pass from Evans (2 pt. Conv. good run from 12)

Third Quarter

CHS — Evans 23 run (Tillman kick), 11:33

CHS — Hatten 2 run (Tillman kick), 6:59

WHS — Nathan 33 run (Cobb kick), 2:22

CHS — Acker 42 pass from Evans (Tillman kick), 0:52

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TEAM STATISTICS

WHS CHS

First Downs 16 18

Total Yards 409 663

Rushes-Yards 46-287 28-378

Fumbles-Lost 0-0 0-0

Com-Att-Int 7-20-3 7-9-0

Passing Yards 122 285

Pen-Yards 4-20 7-85

Punts-Avg. 4-43.75 1-35

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INDIVIDUAL STATISTICS

RUSHING — Crescent, Hatten 12-125, Acker 2-115, Pruitt 2-38, Deveaux 2-21, Evans 3-21, Brawner 1-4, Edwards 5-34, Pressley 1-10; Walhalla, Dean 10-142, Nathan 22-126, Butler 1-13, Cobb 2-9.

PASSING — Crescent, Evans 7-9-0 285; Walhalla, Johnson 7-20-3 122, Cobb 0-1-0 0.

RECEIVING — Crescent, Acker 5-207, Geer-Harrison 2-50, Deveaux 1-27; Walhalla, Patterson 2-61, Donald 1-18, Cobb 1-11, Dean 3-19, Butler 1-13.